

Rahner and Lonergan: A Centenary Tribute

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Rahner and Lonergan

– a centenary tribute

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The year 2004 marks the centenary of the births of two of the outstanding theologians of the twentieth century – the Jesuits Karl Rahner and Bernard Lonergan. Each influenced in his own way generations of theologians and philosophers and continues to be discussed today.

APPROACHING RAHNER

Karl Rahner was born in 1904 in Freiburg, Germany. After leaving school he joined the Society of Jesus and was ordained in 1932. Though he was initially destined for a philosophical career, his dissertation, a study of the epistemology of Thomas Aquinas in the light of modern philosophy (Rahner had attended the seminars of Martin Heidegger in Freiburg), was rejected by his rather traditional supervisor. Though the dissertation was later published as *Spirit in the World*, Rahner would move on a more explicitly theological path – spanning almost half a century – writing on a bewildering variety of topics including spirituality, anthropology, theological methodology, ecclesiology, Christology and religious pluralism.

His literary output was prodigious – even by 1974 it had reached almost three thousand publications. He preferred to stress the *ad hoc* nature of his writing, describing himself as a dilettante. Many of the articles in *Theological Investigations* were originally talks prepared for particular occasions. Rahner never claimed to offer a fully-developed systematic theology along the lines of Karl Barth, for example. Nevertheless, for the student

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The Milltown Institute is hosting an international conference to mark the centenary of the births of Bernard Lonergan and Karl Rahner on 5 and 6 November 2004. Web: www.milltown-institute.ie/rahnerlonergan.htm

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approaching his work it can be a daunting task to know exactly where to begin.

One approach is to begin with a series of interviews he gave over twenty years, collated as *Karl Rahner in Dialogue: Conversations and Interviews 1965-1982*, translated by Harvey Egan, (1986). This is a fine overview of many of the main themes of Rahner's theology in an engaging style, and Rahner's passion and personality emerge in a way that is not always the case in his *Theological Investigations*.

A UNION OF THE SPIRITUAL AND THE THEOLOGICAL

Rahner resists easy categorization. Though traditionally classified as a transcendental Thomist, there are consistent spiritual, ecclesial and pastoral threads underlying his work. His early writings included the best-selling book of prayers, *Encounters with Silence* (1938), a work on the history and practice of spirituality, with Marcel Viller, and collaboration with his brother Hugo on Ignatian spirituality. Indeed, Rahner was later to claim that it was Ignatius of Loyola who had the most significant influence on his work and that he had tried to incorporate some of the 'existentialism' of Ignatius into his theology. He frequently gave retreats and conferences on Ignatius' *Spiritual Exercises*, the aim of which, according to Rahner, is to facilitate a personal experience of God so as to discern what God is saying to a person in the particular circumstances of his or her life.

A similar dynamic is at work in Rahner's renewal of the theology of grace. Whereas traditional theology had focused on grace as a habit or quality of the soul infused by God, Rahner's stress is on the personal and experiential aspect of what he described as God's 'self-communication'. This stress on a personal experience of God, he maintained, was vital if Christianity was to have a future. As societal supports for Christianity recede, the Christian of the future, he once said, will need to be a mystic, to draw strength from within, to be one who has experienced God and who can communicate that experience to others.

This conviction that theology cannot be divorced from experiential knowledge of God is one of the reasons, I believe, for Rahner's perennial contemporaneity. He did not simply deal with human experience in general, or in the abstract, but explored the depths of his *own* human and Christian experience. This is why he kept insisting, in his later years, that his life and work could not be separated. His 'spiritual' writings were not merely the 'overflow' or practical application of his more scientific, theological or philosophical investigations. In this sense, what Rahner once said of Aquinas can also be said of him:

Thomas' *theology is his spiritual life and his spiritual life is his theology*. With him we do not yet find the horrible difference which is often to be observed in later theology, between theology and spiritual life. He thinks theology because he needs it in his spiritual life as its most essential condition, and he thinks theology in such a way that it can become really important for life in the concrete ('Thomas Aquinas', *Everyday Faith*, London: Burns and Oates, 1967, p. 188).

REFORM IN THE CHURCH

Not that Rahner's work was overly focused on the individual's experience with God. He had been a *peritus* or theological consultant at Vatican II and made frequent pleas for the renewal of structures within the Church. He looked forward to a less euro-centric, more tolerant and lay-centred Church, mandated by the ecclesiology of Vatican II. However, Rahner grew increasingly impatient and gloomy towards the end of his life at what he saw as a growing restorationist tendency, particularly in official circles with more and more ecclesial decision-making taking place in Rome.

Rahner never claimed his theology was the last word or that it was unnecessary to move beyond him. He was variously criticised for being either too radical, or not radical enough. Catholic traditionalists complained that he relativized the radical demands of Christianity. Hans Urs von Balthasar, for example, opined that Rahner's anthropologically-oriented theology reduced Christian living to a bland and shallow humanism. The divergences between the two need to be seen against their different backgrounds, temperament and training. Balthasar, the refined aristocrat, was more influenced by the figures of Goethe and Mozart, more at home with the arts than with politics, more phenomenological in his theological approach. If Rahner understands God in terms of the striving of the human spirit and the pre-apprehension of being, Balthasar's approach is more 'from above' stressing that God is first to be praised and served in obedient discipleship. He was convinced that Rahner's theology was too limited by his philosophy with its focus on transcendental ideas and notions.

RAHNER AND BEYOND: HIS LEGACY TODAY

At the other end of the theological spectrum, political theologian Johann Baptist Metz argued that Rahner did not give sufficient importance to the societal dimension of Christianity. The categories most prominent in his theology, he pointed out, are the categories of the intimate, the private and the apolitical. An out

and out transcendental theology runs the risk of not having to enter the field of history since the human person 'is "always already", whether he or she wants to be or not, "with God".'

Rahner, for his part, tried to steer a middle course between the privatization of Christianity on the one hand, and its reduction to a purely humanitarian commitment on the other. He supported Metz's political theology agreeing that theology must criticise those structures in society that oppress individuals and groups. He increasingly sought to complement his transcendental approach with an incorporation of a more historical perspective – testified, for example, in his choice of theological topics.

Yet, in all of this, Rahner did not want to lose sight of the 'always greater' God, the God of 'incomprehensible mystery', who cannot be grasped with rationalistic clarity. This led him to appeal for a greater modesty in theological discourse. In this, his theology has affinities with some postmodern, theological concerns. More radical postmodern stances, of course, eschew all attempts to construct some grand narrative or overarching theoretical system. There is no fixed meaning to anything – whether world, word, text or individual human subject. The centre does not hold because there is no centre. A more moderate form of postmodernism, however, while resisting the search for the means to ground knowledge in a context-neutral fashion, which it regards as illusory, recognizes truth only relative to the community in which a person participates. It is this latter approach which has affinities with Rahner's *Denkstil*, one which does not succumb to total epistemological scepticism, and one which has helped theology come to terms with the situated, partial and fragile character of all human knowing and doing. In a postmodern vein Rahner was aware that language has a life of its own, is open to ever-new interpretations, and so he is cautious about emphasizing too strongly the ability of language to express matters so definitively. All faith formulations, he maintained, are ultimately relativized in the face of Holy Mystery that is their source and goal.

By taking seriously the pluralistic, contextual and interdisciplinary nature of theology, Rahner anticipated many of the themes that preoccupy the current postmodern scene. Religious scholars, influenced by the writings of Derrida, Levinas, Marion and others, insist that our language about God is inadequate if not idolatrous. In reviving the apophatic tradition, they too, not unlike Rahner before them, are advocating a new, more tentative, way of speaking about God.

Though Rahner was not a postmodernist, his theology has at times anticipated some of the characteristics of this style of think-

ing. In drawing attention to the intellectual pluralism of modern society, he was aware of the inescapability and the irreducible nature of such pluralism and the impossibility of integrating the many different schools of theological thought. In the light of the explosion in scientific knowledge too, the 'abstractness' of his theological concepts became increasingly clear to him. In sum, Rahner's lifelong testimony to the mystery of God as integral to the Christian tradition is probably the greatest achievement of this 'unsystematic' theologian.

RAHNER AND LONERGAN

Bernard Lonergan provides a useful example of a different way of doing theology, while remaining within the same context of the Catholic dogmatic tradition. He was born in the same year as Rahner and they both entered the Society of Jesus in their eighteenth year. At that time there was a largely uniform pattern of training in the order, so that the education of both scholars would have many similarities, nourished along the way by the same spirituality.

Lonergan combined his studies of philosophy in Heythrop College, Oxfordshire, with a BA in languages and mathematics at the University of London. His interest in mathematics and science was a life-long one, and eventually had a definite influence in his notion of theological method. He studied theology in Rome in the years leading up to the Second World War, completing his doctorate in 1940. After some intervening years teaching theology in his own country, he returned to Rome to lecture there on dogmatic theology, especially in Christology and Trinity, from 1953 to 1965.

The huge lecture-hall of the Gregorian University brought before him in a very immediate way the problem posed by a diversity of philosophies, even among the disciplined ranks of Catholic seminarians. It also raised the concerns that would lead eventually to his work on theological method. In particular he began to reflect in a sustained way on the different kinds of understanding involved in the various disciplines, in literature, in science, and in the various departments of theology. These were the problems with which he grappled in his monumental philosophical work, *Insight: A Study of Human Understanding*, first published in 1957. As a teacher of theology Lonergan was concerned about the philosophical underpinning of the faith and about how to find some basis on which a reasonable consensus might be sought, to guide us through what he called the 'polymorphism' of contemporary thought.

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A 'RATIONAL' THEOLOGIAN

One of the key principles of Lonergan's approach rests on the fact that all human beings have minds, and our minds function according to a readily recognizable pattern. Lonergan felt that this pattern could become a basis for some unity in our approach to the diversity of fields and systems with which we are confronted. From this emerges his famous four-fold pattern of human thinking: experiencing, understanding, judging and deciding. This aspect of his teaching has been found very helpful in philosophical circles and, for students in particular, forms a gateway into many of the problems before them.

Not so easy to grasp is the underlying principle of this structure, especially that which concerns the difference between the second and the third stages in this pattern. This is a structure for reaching the real, and Lonergan has a certain view of what realism means. He calls it a critical realism, which he distinguishes clearly from another interpretation which he calls an immediate realism. The distinction between these two, as he interprets them, is one of the basic discoveries of his system of thought, and he tells us in the Introduction to *Insight* that 'one has not made it yet if one has no clear memory of its startling strangeness'. Lonergan considers that this discovery, which in a later work he calls intellectual conversion, is comparatively rare on the academic plane. Consequently he finds himself ploughing a somewhat different furrow from that of many of his philosophical and theological colleagues.

METHOD IN THEOLOGY

In the middle of the 1960s illness put an end to Lonergan's tenure in the Gregorian University. He returned to his own country and after a few years was able to resume his academic studies in Regis College, Toronto. These studies bore fruit in 1972 with the publication of his second major work, *Method in Theology*, a programmatical essay on the nature of theology in the light of a contemporary philosophy. Lonergan continued contributing to conferences and learned publications for the rest of his career, taking part in the annual workshops on his writings in Boston College. During these years he received considerable international recognition, being honoured with no less than nineteen honorary degrees from universities in Canada and the United States. He received one of his country's highest civil awards, being made a Companion of the Order of Canada in 1971, and a Fellow of the British Academy in 1975.

Lonergan's contribution to theology is somewhat different from that of his German confrère. The works that reflect the earlier part of his career, when he was lecturing in Rome, are significant, first

of all, in the historical dimension they add to the study of Christology and of the Trinity. In his treatises on these subjects, his view of the consciousness of Christ, and his view of the Trinity as a community of conscious subjects, represent high-points of theological insight, which the reflection of subsequent theologians has scarcely done justice to.

However as regards the actual treatment of concrete theological issues, it must be pointed out that his publications, while valuable in themselves, are nowhere as wide-ranging or as immediate as those of Karl Rahner. When Lonergan returned to his task after his illness, he operated under a certain 'self-denying ordinance', electing to leave to others the many concrete issues of the day in order to concentrate on the one concern which he felt was crucial for all the rest and yet neglected by most, namely the question of method. His study *Insight* was a remote preparation for treating this question. The issue was a recurrent theme in his publications in the intervening years; and then came his crowning work, *Method in Theology*.

Only in this book do we meet the mature Lonergan. Readers of *Insight* have sometimes felt out of sympathy with the rigorous intellectualism of that earlier work. In *Method in Theology* Lonergan advances to a more holistic treatment of the human subject, where the volitional and affective aspects of the person are better integrated into the total picture. This enables him to face up to some of the crucial hermeneutical problems that have dogged theology, especially since the time of Heidegger and Bultmann. Drawing also on some key concepts of spirituality, he is able to give an account not only of the nature of theology itself, but of the kind of person a theologian must be. No longer is theology to be described as the science of God. A basis has now been worked out on which theology can be satisfactorily distinguished from religion, and theology is seen as reflection on religion, and its role is to mediate between religion and culture. As for the theologian, he or she must be a person intellectually, morally and religiously converted, for, as Augustine said, in a phrase beloved by Heidegger, only through love does one enter into truth.

Lonergan's key contribution, then, is to be characterized more on the level of performance than of content. He made a deliberate choice to concentrate on understanding what is involved in the actual process of doing theology rather than on wrestling with particular theological issues in themselves. It was a choice for quality rather than for quantity, for depth rather than for range. While his work therefore might seem restricted in respect of the number of topics discussed, its potential relevance is as wide as the entire field of theology.

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Method in Theology is the watershed from which there has come a flood-tide of subsequent reflection and publication, as scholars in various countries labour at the immense task of implementing the programme Lonergan has outlined, and at applying his principles in various concrete issues. The disciplines in which his approach is found relevant include not only the various branches of theology but also philosophy, literature, jurisprudence and even economics. A scholar from Uppsala some time ago told me that the number of theses world-wide on Lonergan exceeds even the number on Rahner.

Lonergan's study of method is no straightforward book. Even Rahner in his one essay on the topic seems to have missed the point. The criterion for judging Lonergan, therefore, lies not in the number of theological questions which he himself has illuminated in his writings, but in the vitality of the movement engendered by his method, and in the success with which it is found by subsequent scholars to confront the pluralism, polymorphism and chaos of contemporary academic thought.

A central ministry. One ministry, however, has hardly been mentioned. Although fundamentally Christian, it was not something which the people knew much about – nor, for that matter, did many priests. It was not built into the job description, like teaching altar servers not to trip you up, or visiting. Indeed, it was something that had long been assumed to be for religious professionals only, of no relevance to the parish rank and file. However, some priests, when relieved of the all-consuming round of parish routines, began to hear people asking to be listened to – in a more profound, more accepting, more fraternal way. In a few parishes this Christ-like listening was becoming central to the parish ministry. This 'listening' was spiritual direction.

—DESMOND RYAN, *The Catholic Parish* (Sheed and Ward, London) p. 177